

Maamarei Mordechai

הסבר לפי ממש פשוט

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Amalek is recalled for being an ungrateful thorn in Bnei Yisroel's side.

זָכוֹר אֶת אֲשֶׁר-עָשָׂה לְךָ עַמְלֵק בְּדֶרֶךְ בְּצֵאתְכֶם מִמִּצְרָיִם:

"Recall all that Amalek did to you, on the way when you were leaving from Egypt." (Devarim 25:17).

Who was Amalek? And does the Torah give every generation a positive command to destroy Amalek?

There is an Amalek that is Esav's grandson. (Bereishis 36:12). However, the Torah makes it clear that Esav is kin, and no distinction is made about his grandson. (Devarim 2:5). There is another Amalek. In the account of the war of the four kings, the Torah says that the kings returned and came to Kadesh and "struck the whole field of the Amalekites." (Bereishis 14:7). This occurred during the lifetime of Avraham. While some sources say this verse is an example of a proleptic name (used in that narrative even though the territory would only obtain that name later in history), it seems most contextually and simply accurate to reason that there were an earlier people named Amalek, prior to Esav naming a grandson that name.

Amalek was not simply a nation that suddenly appeared in the wilderness to attack Bnei Yisroel. It was not a dispute between cousins. The Torah is much more forgiving of such a dispute. The Torah gives great concession to Edom not providing Bnei Yisroel with water, and even Amon and Moav going out to battle with Bnei Yisroel. However, the Torah gives this Amalek no quarter. The reason is, the attack on Bnei Yisroel in the wilderness was not this Amalek's first transgression.

The Torah's first reference to "the field of Amalek" places an Amalekite power in the region generations before Yetziyas Mitzrayim. The Amalek whom the Torah identifies as the grandson of Eisav may have inherited a name and an established identity that already existed in the land. It was not Esav's grandson that attacked Bnei Yisroel.

Shortly after Yetziyas Mitzrayim, when Bnei Yisrael were traveling through the wilderness, "Amalek came and fought with Yisroel at Rephidim." (Shemos 17:8). Yehoshua led the people into battle, while Moshe stood atop the mountain. (Ibid 17:10). When Moshe raised his hands, Yisroel prevailed; when he lowered them, Amalek prevailed. (Ibid 17:11). Yehoshua ultimately weakened Amalek and won the day. (Ibid 17:13). But something unusual happened after the battle. Hashem told Moshe, "Write this as a remembrance in the book... for I will surely blot out the memory of Amalek from under heaven." (Ibid 17:14). The Torah then concludes, "A war for Hashem against Amalek from generation to generation" (Ibid 17:16). It is clearly Hashem that will battle Amalek, and it is only an obligation that Hashem took upon Himself.

Moshe later commanded Bnei Yisroel to recall Amalek. (Devarim 25:17). The Torah then gives a detailed description of what Amalek did. Bnei Yisroel encountered them on the way, and they struck the rear of the traveling nation; Amalek attacked the laggards, the tired and wary. (Ibid 25:18). Further, Amalek did not have any fear of Hashem. (Ibid). Then the Torah commands, when Bnei Yisroel are safe in their land, that is when they should blot out the memory of Amalek, from under the heavens; do not forget. (Ibid 25:19). The words *תִּמְחָה אֶת-זֵכֶר עֲמָלֵק* can also mean “you shall blot out the recalling of Amalek.”

The Torah gives the reason for blotting out Amalek. There was an encounter. The Torah did not say Amalek attacked first. In Shemos the Torah said, “And Amalek came and warred with Yisroel.” (Shmos 17:8). This appears to be a contradiction. If Amalek came to war with Bnei Yisroel, then how was it a mere encounter? The explanation is tied to the end of the pasuk in Devarim that says, “they did not fear Hashem.” If they warred with Bnei Yisroel they did not fear Hashem. The Torah is hinting at Amalek being like a *gazlan*, a nighttime thief. Chazal teach the nighttime thief steals at night because he fears man but not Hashem. Moshe told Bnei Yisroel that while Amalek did come to war with Bnei Yisroel, they encountered Bnei Yisroel but did not attack. They waited for Bnei Yisroel to move past, feigned being friendly, and then attacked the rear. They attacked the stragglers, the weak, the slow. They feared Yisroel but did not fear Hashem.

This is why Hashem turned special attention to blotting out Amalek more than Midian, Amon, Moav, Amori, Bashan, or anyone else that attacked Bnei Yisroel. It was because they came to war with Bnei Yisroel but only attacked the rear and the weak. And there was another reason.

Avraham saved Amalek and restored its land and possessions. The Torah says that after Avraham prevailed in the war and chased away the four kings to Damascus, he restored the possessions to the losing parties. (Bereishis 14:16). This would include Amalek, who was not one of the five kings, but was devastated by the four kings. Yet, despite this, Amalek went and attacked Avraham’s grandchildren. They did it even after Hashem brought the people out with signs and wonders. And they did not fight straight up and honorably. They feigned friendship and then attacked the rear and weak. This is what Hashem could not tolerate. This is why Hashem wants to blot them out.

Moshe told Bnei Yisroel that they only have an obligation to blot out Amalek – and only recalling or the remembrance of Amalek – when Bnei Yisroel are secure in their land. That is why Shaul was given the task to finish the job. However, to be clear, the job of actually destroying Amalek and wiping them from memory is Hashem’s. It is Hashem’s battle. It will be when Bnei Yisroel are secure in their land – in the End of Days, the time of Moshiach – that Bnei Yisroel will no longer have to recall Amalek. That command to recall them will no longer be applicable. All will be made right in the world. Hashem will have warred and prevailed – so to speak – over Amalek. There will be no purpose in recalling Amalek. The message is the memory of Amalek is not meant to preserve hatred for its own sake. It is meant to preserve a warning: when power is divorced from morality and the weak become targets rather than people deserving protection, society has lost its fear of Hashem. Fear Hashem above any fear of mankind.